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Week 9: Thoughts on Chapter 2 of The Persona Lifecycle

In this reflection, I actually want to focus on the refreshing perspective that I was provided with when reading this book chapter. As a graduate student who has been focused in HCI research for a few years now, I am more familiar with the academic community approach to user-centered design (UCD) and know rather very little about the *industrial* perspective on UCD. I felt that the way in which this chapter explained and reinforced certain points about how to create personas gave me a much better understanding of what kinds of issues are important and have to be dealt with in the real-world design industry, vs. the academic community. This is actually what I felt like was the most valuable knowledge I got out of the reading this week.

In the academic HCI community, many models and approaches are presented in a more “purist” and theoretical manner, where there is often not a real-world context in which the actual practice of these models is situated. A theory or model that is presented is usually expected to be taken as it is. But a huge portion of this reading heavily situates the implementation of the persona lifecycle with respect to integrating UCD in a real company. The author often mentions how to persuade different entities in the company to accept and support these UCD approaches, which the academic community might not think that much about – the general consensus in the academic community is that everyone believes UCD is important, so they don’t spend time convincing each other why. But real-world companies have to deal with many issues like time, resource, budget, and personnel constraints that the chapter claims make companies feel like they don’t have the time to go all-in on the work that is needed for robust UCD in product development. So it is interesting (at least to me) that the chapter spends a lot of time explaining how to mitigate all of these issues.

For example, the chapter claims that it is difficult to ask higher-ups for extra time and resources to focus on users early, when the priority of the company is usually to start on actual product development as early as possible. So it talks about the struggle of UCD people struggling in “swimming upstream” in the waterfall development model, where team members are often already progressing onto a next step when you are still trying to consolidate information from a previous step for review or want them to stop and reflect on some user-related insight resulting from a previous step in the waterfall. See “However, in some cases you will find that waterfall activities start before you are finished with the first three phases of the persona lifecycle because no one is willing to wait for the information you are working to provide.” (pg. 54) To be honest, reading statements like this made me rather sad, but it was very useful to know that these are real and widespread issues for UCD designers in industry. It was also interesting to me that the chapter made an effort to emphasize that personas “do not replace existing processes” but rather help “structure user-centered thinking”, as if assuming the reader is concerned about having to change current processes (which is very difficult to do in a large company).

Another emphasis by the chapter that I wasn’t used to seeing in more academically-focused literature was emphasis on and encouragement of compromised implementations of the

persona lifecycle. The chapter talks about “discount usability techniques” (it was my first time hearing this term) and characterized personas as a very good form of this type of technique. “Discount” usually means something cheap and emphasizes cost-effectiveness. I think in pushing forward a lot of theories and approaches in academic HCI research, people do not emphasize cost-effectiveness that much of the time and put more focus on the best way to improve something in a more “purist” perspective. This is because sometimes over-emphasizing cost-effectiveness in academic pursuits, if done over theoretical interest, seems unappealing and comes off a bit as a “cop-out” attitude. However, it is clear that using “discount” methods is in reality an important option, mainly because company members have to deal with many suboptimal conditions in the development process. The chapter also talks about how it is okay to skip certain steps of the persona lifecycle if needed, and even goes into explaining how to determine which steps are more important if this has to be done. It also talks about how the creation of *assumption personas* is an acceptable option if data can’t be collected, which seems like an extremely discount option in that it forgoes the data basis which seems to be so important. But I think that the emphasis here is that under restrictions, it is better to do some than none.

Lastly, I felt that the E-Business Server example of implementing persona lifecycles surprised me in describing how much work was done by the UCD team to get the rest of the product team on board with using personas. When reading through the lifecycle descriptions, I had an understanding that communication was needed with the product team about the personas, but I had no idea that this level of “intra-organizational marketing” was needed to get other members of the company on board with what seemed to myself like something that should be regarded as important in the first place. For example, the UCD team talked about how they created “Name Your Persona” contest and fun cutouts of people and even made what seemed like campaign posters to put around the office. Perhaps previously I had taken for granted the idea that if UCD was part of a project, their contributions would already be respected as much as those of other technical team members. But it seemed to me like this UCD team did a lot of work to persuade the team members of the project to work with them – although their internal marketing work was very impressive, it made me feel like they had to do a lot more than their job description (the user-centered design) portion just to get other people to validate them. Alas, the very creation of the persona concept in the first place is to make UCD accessible to non-UCD personnel, so the company-situated approach of personas makes a lot of sense.